

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

FRIDAY 18 SEPTEMBER 2026



SAUDI CRUDE STOPS WAITING FOR THE STRAIT TO OPEN AND STARTS CHANGING SHIPS OUTSIDE IT — AND THE OIL PRICE BREAKS LOWER FOR THE FIRST TIME SINCE THE TANKER WAR BEGAN ([P3](#), [P14](#))

THE WORLD

Twelve ships crossed Hormuz on Wednesday and three of them went dark doing it — then Moscow and Beijing voted the inspectors out of existence

Twelve Desks · One World

THE MACRO DESK

The Fed raised rates into an oil shock and the whole curve rallied the next day: not a market fighting a central bank, a market paying one

THE RABBIT HOLE

Model rocketry, all the way down: a logarithmic alphabet, a legal line at a hundred and sixty newton-seconds, and a hazmat fee charged by the box

Source: Wikimedia Commons — the crude-oil tanker POLAR ADVENTURE. A laden crude carrier at sea, representative of the traffic the Strait of Hormuz normally carries and of the cargoes now changing ships outside it ([P3](#)). Honestly labelled; not a specific vessel in this week's reporting.

THIS ISSUE · THE WEEKDAY BOOK · NO. 106

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FROM THE DESK

“The Net interprets censorship as damage and routes around it.”

Attributed to John Gilmore; quoted by Philip Elmer-DeWitt, TIME, 6 December 1993

The founding optimism of a whole era — and Gilmore has said publicly that he never found where he first said it.

THE STRIP · AT THURSDAY’S CLOSE

US 10-year	4.951%	▼ -5bp
Gold (spot /oz)	\$4,307	▲ +1.0%
Bitcoin	\$76,357	— flat through
Brent crude	\$104.82	▼ -\$1.01
DXY (dollar)	100.23	— -0.03%
USD/SGD	1.2771	▼ SGD softer
STI	5,660.52	▲ +0.5%
VWRA (All-World)	\$191.50	— 16 Sep, held

Levels at or around the 17 Sep close; decision-day prints differ and are given on **p14**. VWRA carried as held. Not advice.¹

THE MERIDIAN INDEX · FOURTEEN NUMBERS FROM THIS ISSUE, IN AN ORDER OF OUR CHOOSING

12 — ships through the Strait of Hormuz on Wednesday — **p3**

85+ — ships through it on a normal day — **p3**

3 — of the twelve that crossed with their transponders off — **p3**

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SOURCES ¹ Levels at or around the 17 Sep close; ten-year double-sourced (CNBC; TradingEconomics), gold cross-checked on three feeds, DXY, USD/SGD and STI single-sourced — caveats on **p14**. Every Index figure is sourced on the desk page cited beside it.

THE MERIDIAN DISPATCH · THE GULF, DAY 201

Riyadh stops waiting for the strait to open, and starts changing ships outside it

Escalation and price moved in opposite directions this week. On Thursday the American president weighed aloud whether to “annihilate” the Iranian regime — and Brent fell anyway, because Saudi crude has begun transferring hull to hull off Oman, and the physical system rebuilt its own bypass in six days.

this story  

Twelve ships went through the Strait of Hormuz on Wednesday. Three of them went dark doing it, and two more switched their transponders off mid-passage.¹ Against a normal day of eighty-five or more, twelve is a ruin. Against Tuesday’s six, it is a doubling.¹

Both readings are true, and the market chose the second. Brent settled Thursday at US\$104.82, a dollar lower, then slid a further two to three per cent overnight to around US\$102 — the first sustained break lower since the tanker exchange began.¹ It broke lower on the day Washington escalated its language furthest: the president, in a phone interview, said he was near a decision on resuming large-scale strikes — “Do I want to go in and annihilate them, or do I not?”

What moved the price was shipping logistics. Riyadh has begun making crude available to Asian refiners by ship-to-ship transfer just outside the strait, off Oman’s port of Sohar: shuttle tankers run the gauntlet inbound, and the receiving vessels never enter the Gulf.¹ It replaces a bypass destroyed on 10–11 September, when drones launched from Iraqi territory struck the East–West pipeline to Yanbu.¹

390 kb/d

GULF NET DIESEL AND GASOIL EXPORTS IN AUGUST — JUST OVER A QUARTER OF PRE-WAR LEVELS, AND THE NUMBER THAT CARRIES THIS STORY INTO THE INFLATION PRINT (P14)

The strait is open on paper and closed in practice; the pipeline that was the answer is broken; the answer to the broken answer is a hull-to-hull transfer off a neutral port.⁴ The same day, thinly

sourced wire copy reported fresh activity at Iran’s most deeply buried nuclear site.⁴

NEW DELHI PETROLEUM MINISTRY, AS REPORTED

Not whose fault — we already left. India routes about seventy per cent of its crude outside the strait, up from fifty-five, buying from more than forty nations.²

TEHRAN / BEIJING / TAMPA THE THREE OTHER FRAMINGS

Tehran calls the tanker strikes a war crime in service of an economic war, and says this nation “will not surrender to the bullies.”

THE CHATTER · TWO COMMUNITIES, TWO SUBJECTS

The technical forums have stopped arguing about who is right and started building dashboards — strait-status trackers, a “Show HN” page answering only whether Hormuz is open, a browser game called *Hormuz Minesweeper*.

THE SCEPTIC · NOBODY AGREES ON THE COUNT

Begin with the claims that did not survive contact. Iran said a Panama-flagged tanker struck a mine; CENTCOM said that was false.⁴ Then the measurement: Lloyd’s List counts only cargo vessels over 10,000 tonnes, Kpler counts differently, and three of Wednesday’s twelve were dark.³ On price the dissent runs both ways with no middle: Goldman is reported near US\$85, Rystad models above US\$140 and a recession.³ The honest correction to this desk’s own instinct that no barrels were lost: the IEA calls this the largest supply disruption in the history of the oil market, supply down 5.7 million barrels a day.³

SOURCES 1 Transits, dark crossings and baselines: Windward; Lloyd’s List Intelligence; Kpler; Al Jazeera. Brent, WTI and the Sohar transfers: Fortune; CNBC; OilPrice; Finimize. Trump’s remarks and the UNGA meeting: Times of Israel; anews. The East–West pipeline: Al Jazeera; CNBC; militarynews.com. 2 India’s re-routing: the Petroleum Ministry via NewsOnAir; Autocar India. Tehran: Al Jazeera; Iranian state media via GlobalSecurity. Beijing: Xinhua; Al-Monitor; rebuttal from CSIS. CENTCOM: GlobalSecurity Day 201; ABC News; USNI News. 3 Community read: Hacker News threads; Splash247; gCaptain; Trump’s remarks via Yahoo. Counting methods: Lloyd’s List; Al Jazeera. Forecasts as reported: Goldman and Rystad via a roundup, single-sourced on Goldman; Fesharaki via Bloomberg. IEA Oil Market Report, September 2026. 4 The Security Council veto: AP via Local10 and Courthouse News; the earlier procedural vote is separate (UN SC/16448). The nuclear-site report rests on one low-grade syndicated outlet, flagged in the text. Denied Iranian claims and the unpromulgated zone: CENTCOM via GlobalSecurity; PBS; Washington Post and AP.

AROUND THE DESKS · EUROPE

The bank was not hacked. The government's inbox was — and the request that followed looked perfectly lawful

Seven hundred Revolut customers lost their identity documents this week without a single system being breached.

The breach disclosed on Thursday is small by the standards of the genre and much more interesting than most.¹ They did not get in. The data was requested from the bank using a compromised institutional email account belonging to the prefecture of Reggio Calabria — that is, the attackers impersonated an Italian government authority making the kind of lawful data request every European bank is obliged to answer.¹

The group calling itself “iamnotavillain” has demanded US\$3 million and threatened to sell the data on to other criminal organisations within twenty-four hours if it goes unpaid.¹ Two regulators are now in: the public prosecutor in Reggio Calabria has opened an investigation, and Britain’s Information Commissioner’s Office is looking at it after Revolut self-reported.¹

What makes this worth a column rather than a line is that the vulnerability is not a product defect. It is the compliance channel itself.

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT WOULD CHANGE THE READING

Two things would. If the prefecture’s account was compromised through an ordinary credential theft rather than anything novel, this is a phishing story wearing an institutional costume, and the lesson is mundane.¹

STILL ON THE SHELF · THE HIMALAYAN FLOOD, THREE WEEKS ON

The recovery, not the collapse, is now the story. On 26 August a section of glacier and bedrock roughly 600 metres wide gave way at about 5,200 metres above the Lhende Khola in Tibet’s Xizang region,

damming the river; when the blockage failed the surge tore through settlements in Nepal’s Rasuwa district and carried bodies some 240 kilometres into India.² Weeks later both governments are still struggling to recover, which is the live fact. Note the scientific restraint, which is rarer than it should be: researchers say climate change is altering glaciers, snow, permafrost and slopes across the Hindu Kush Himalaya, but that it is “too early to determine what role climate change played in this specific event.”²

IN BRIEF

Amazon cannot restore the Gulf. AWS has told customers it is unable to bring back access to cloud facilities in Bahrain and parts of the UAE damaged by Iranian drone strikes, saying the damage “exceeded what its services are designed to withstand” — an underreported second-order cost of the war.²

Oman still has no new date. The Iran–Gulf security talks postponed on 13 September “at the request of some regional countries” have not been rescheduled; Muscat’s stated reason is that conditions are not right.³

War-risk cover is now the cost of the voyage. Hormuz war-risk premiums run at 7.5 to 10 per cent of hull value, against roughly a quarter of a per cent before hostilities: a US\$100m tanker pays US\$3m to US\$10m to make one transit. Current, though not date-stamped to this week.⁴

Riyadh declined to retaliate for the pipeline strike at the Iraqi prime minister’s request, after Baghdad dismissed the commander in the province the drones flew from — while reserving the right to “take all measures necessary.”⁴

THE CHATTER · A CAUTION ABOUT THE PICTURES

A decades-old photograph of a sinking tanker has been circulating this month falsely labelled as current footage from the Gulf, and has been fact-checked as such.⁴

SOURCES 1 The Revolut breach, its method and scope: Euronews; Irish Times. 2 The ransom demand, the conflicting bitcoin figure, the Reggio Calabria prosecutor and the Information Commissioner’s inquiry: as above, plus Cybernews and Crypto Times — the bitcoin figure and the larger-breach claim are each single-sourced and flagged as such. 3 The glacier collapse, the dam failure and the casualty figures: Earth.com; NBC News; TIME; The New Humanitarian — figures vary by source. 4 AWS and the Security Council: GlobalSecurity Day 201. Rezaei on the exclusion zone: Washington Post and AP; PBS. The postponed talks: Al Jazeera; The National. Saudi–Iraq handling: Al Jazeera; Inquirer. War-risk premiums: fairwayeta; S&P Global citing Marsh. The recirculated tanker photograph: Yahoo News fact-check.

THE LITTLE RED DOT · THE AIR, AND THE PRICE OF A CAR

The rain bought two days, not a resolution — and on Thursday the particles came back

Yesterday this page recorded the haze easing. The agency's own daily numbers now show the easing was a dip inside an ongoing episode: fine-particle readings fell to 34–59 micrograms on Tuesday and climbed to 46–78 by Thursday evening, with dry conditions holding and the wind unchanged.

this story  

Read the series rather than the headline. The National Environment Agency has published a haze update almost every day this month, and the sequence tells a different story from any single reading.¹ The 24-hour index peaked at 145 around midnight on 15 September, and the agency has been issuing daily advisories since 4 September, when the index crossed 100 in the central region.¹ Prevailing winds remain from the south-east to east-southeast, carrying smoke from southern Sumatra and Kalimantan, and the agency has said hazy conditions may persist while the dry weather holds.¹

The institutional response is real and worth naming precisely, because it is the part that is working.¹

46–78

MICROGRAMS PER CUBIC METRE OF FINE PARTICLES
ACROSS SINGAPORE AT 5PM ON THURSDAY — UP FROM 34–
59 TWO DAYS EARLIER.

AND THE OTHER NUMBER: A CAR PLATE AT S\$133,009

The first September bidding exercise closed at 4pm on Wednesday the 9th and produced a record. The Category A certificate of entitlement — engines to 1,600cc and no more than 130 brake horsepower — closed at S\$133,009, up S\$4,508 or 3.5 per cent, breaking the S\$129,000 record set on 8 July and

crossing S\$130,000 for the first time.² Two mechanisms are doing the work, and the authority named the first itself: this exercise followed a three-week interval rather than the usual two, and dealers say the extra week let orders accumulate.² The next exercise opens on 21 September, three days from now.

IN BRIEF

THE CHATTER · AND THE READING NOBODY TRUSTS

The register on HardwareZone's forums is weary recognition rather than alarm — gallows humour about the big red patch on the maps, the skyline compared to a watercolour, notes swapped on cloud seeding, and a population plainly pattern-matching to 2013 and 2015.³ All of this is forum sentiment, not measurement, and the specific pairings are single-sourced to posts this desk could not date.

THE SCEPTIC · THE SUSPICION IS WIDELY HELD, AND IT IS WRONG

The gap is arithmetic, not concealment. The international indices publish a one-hour fine-particle figure; Singapore's headline index is a 24-hour rolling average.³ Which leaves a fair criticism standing on the other side: choosing to headline a 24-hour average during a fast-moving episode is precisely what manufactures the suspicion.⁴

SOURCES 1 Daily fine-particle figures, winds, sources and the persistence guidance: National Environment Agency haze situation updates, the 17 September edition single-sourced. 2 The 15 September peak and the start of daily advisories on 4 September: Mothership; AsiaOne. Haze Task Force composition, action plans and the 3 August regional alert: Ministry of Sustainability and the Environment, oral reply to a parliamentary question — dated to that reply, not to this week. 3 COE results from the 9 September exercise: The Star; AsiaOne; Motorist; primary figures at LTA OneMotoring and the LTA open dataset. Retrenchment and employment figures: Ministry of Manpower advance release, 31 July. The stablecoin consultation: MAS; Reed Smith. Grand Prix dates and closures: Singapore GP; Formula 1; Singapore Tourism Board. 4 Community sentiment: HardwareZone Singapore forum threads, characterised in our own words; the reading pairings are undated posts and are not printed as measurements. Averaging methodology: the World Air Quality Index project's documentation. The standing legal critique: Alan Khee-Jin Tan, NUS Law working paper 002/2015; SMU School of Law; NUS Faculty of Science — all pre-2026, paraphrased rather than quoted.

BUY IT ONCE · FOUNTAIN-PEN INK & PAPER

The most celebrated ink in the hobby does not reliably dry — and that is not a defect, it is the mechanism

Ink is barely thicker than water, and two knobs govern everything it does. Learn them and you can judge any bottle and any sheet cold — including why the sheen you are paying for is the same physical fact as the smudge on your cuff.

this story  

Start with the fluid. Fountain-pen ink is water, soluble dye, surfactants to lower surface tension, humectant — usually glycerin — to slow drying, a trace of biocide and a pH adjuster, at a working viscosity of one to fifteen centipoise where water is about one.¹ It is barely thicker than water, which is why capillary action alone moves it through a feed. Two knobs govern everything, and they pull against each other: lower surface tension gives better flow and a wetter line, plus more feathering and more nib creep; higher viscosity gives a drier line but a longer dry time.¹

The paper's mechanism is prettier. Untreated paper is a mat of cellulose with capillary gaps between the fibres; put ink on it and water is pulled into the network, dragging dye radially. **Sizing** is the countermeasure: internal sizing goes into the pulp and governs bleed-through, surface sizing is applied to the formed sheet and keeps ink on top of the fibres.¹ Grams per square metre tells you almost nothing about any of it, which is why a 52-gram Japanese sheet beats 80-gram copier stock. **pigment**, whose particles lodge in the fibre for real permanence at the risk of caking; **iron gall**, which oxidises inside the fibre — tamed now, but Rohrer & Klingner still say flush weekly, and steel corrodes faster than gold; and document certification.¹

\$0.24 / \$1.07

PER MILLILITRE: DIAMINE'S 80ML BOTTLE AGAINST WEARINGEUL, A KOREAN HOUSE FOUNDED IN 2018. THE DEAREST INK ON THE LADDER IS NOT A LUXURY LOGO — IT IS THE HOBBY

THE WHITE-LABEL TRUTHS

Sailor is the engine behind the shop exclusives — Bungubox's line and Nagasawa's eighty-plus Kobe colours are both made by Sailor to the shop's specification.²

THE CHATTER · THE GRAIL THAT PROVES THE MECHANISM

Organics Studio Nitrogen is the clearest cult object here, and Goulet Pens' own review explains why: a deep cerulean with a dazzling red sheen that, in saturated areas, still smears days later and dusts ink onto your fingers.³

THE SCEPTIC · DIVIDE, AND COUNT THE PAGES

The sleight of hand is the denominator, not the price. Sailor Ink Studio at US\$18 looks cheaper than Iroshizuku at US\$28.50 until you divide: ninety cents a millilitre against fifty-seven.³

SINGAPORE, AND NEXT ON THE BENCH · YOU PICK NO. 107

Pepper mills & salt grinders — the only kitchen tool whose entire value is a burr geometry you never see.

Tea ware (teapots, kettles & gaiwan) — Yixing clay that seasons like cast iron, and a four-dollar gaiwan that beats the infuser.

Wooden cutting boards & butcher blocks — end-grain versus edge-grain, and what tropical humidity does to both.

SOURCES 1 Ink composition, the surfactant window, biocide loading and viscosity: US Patent 7201792; JetPens; Fountain Pen Love. Sizing, internal against surface, and waterleaf: The Pen Archive; FP Revolution. The surface-tension and viscosity trade-off is our synthesis of those mechanisms. 2 Pigment and iron gall, Platinum Carbon Black, the Sailor nano inks and the Rohrer & Klingner dry times: JetPens; Unsharpen; Goulet Pens — the settling comparison is a community observation and the dry times are single-sourced per ink. Tomoe River S: Hobonichi; Papeterie Makkura; The Gentleman Stationer — the technical deltas rest substantially on one analysis. Clairefontaine and Rhodia: Exacompta Clairefontaine. Cosmo Air Light: Galen Leather. Graphilo: Kobahe. Bungubox and Nagasawa made by Sailor: Mountain of Ink; Pen Chalet; kobe-nagasawa.com. Montblanc's manufacturer: an open Fountain Pen Network thread, unresolved and printed as unresolved. 3 Organics Studio Nitrogen: Goulet Pens; Fountain Pen Network. Old stock against Sanzen: Hunter Paper Co. and Yamamoto Paper. The per-millilitre ladder and bottle sizes: maker and retailer listings read 17 September and not page-verified. Page yields and bottle longevity: One Pen Show; Goldspot — the collector arithmetic is ours. Humidity, mould, cockling and nib creep: Pen Chalet; StorHub Singapore; Goldspot; CityLuxe's Singapore guide, single-sourced and a retailer. Local stockists and Atelier Musubi: cityluxe.sg; fookhing.com.sg; musu.bi.

SILICON & SOVEREIGNTY · A MODEL THAT WILL NOT TALK TO YOU

Forty million dollars for a model whose only outputs are yes, no, and a number

TypeSafe AI came out of stealth on Monday with a model called Jev that refuses to write prose, code or conversation.

this story 

The interesting thing is what it cannot do. On 15 September TypeSafe AI emerged from stealth with around US\$40 million in seed funding led by DCVC, and put a model called **Jev** into waitlisted early access the same day.¹ Jev takes unstructured state plus a *typed question* and returns a typed answer — a Choice, a Score, or a boolean the company has named a Noul — each with a calibrated confidence.¹

The founders matter to the claim. Diogo Almeida, the chief executive, is a former OpenAI researcher described as a co-inventor of the reinforcement-learning-from-human-feedback line that became ChatGPT; Erik Gafni is chief technology officer and Sasha Sheng chief operating officer.¹ The training method is called Reinforcement Learning for Calibrated Decisions, coined for this launch, and it ships with no paper, no ablation and no weights.¹

777 in 0.7s

JUDGMENTS RETURNED ACROSS THIRTY-SEVEN DOCUMENTS IN AN INDEPENDENT TEST BY EVERY'S MIKE TAYLOR, AT AN ESTIMATED COST OF ABOUT A QUARTER OF A CENT — ROUGHLY TWENTY-FIVE TIMES FASTER AND 580 TIMES CHEAPER THAN THE FRONTIER COMPARISON

The delta on this desk's last three outings is that this is the first credible argument that a large slice of AI compute demand is being served by something that is not a chatbot at all. **HA-Jev**, was published on the 17th, turning Jev answers into probability sensors, choice selectors and scores with four services, requiring Home Assistant 2026.9 or later and your own key.²

THE CHATTER · HALF DELIGHTED, HALF TAKING IT APART

The Hacker News launch thread reached roughly 1,655 points and 456 comments inside a day, and the count varies by snapshot, so treat the figure as a timestamp rather than a total.class, against a determined effort to dismantle the numbers. Three lines of attack recur — that skipping public leaderboards was convenient; that “RLCD” and “parallel sampler” are vocabulary invented for a launch with nothing inspectable behind them; and open irritation at the word “frontier” for something that cannot hold a conversation.ramon156, made the cleanest technical objection: seventy milliseconds against 329 seconds is not a comparison if the baseline is generating full chain-of-thought.²

IN BRIEF

Huawei doubled its SuperPoD. At Huawei Connect in Shanghai on 17 September the Atlas 960 was unveiled at 30 exaflops FP8 and 60 FP4, 4,460 terabytes of memory, 34 petabytes per second of interconnect and up to 15,488 Ascend chips — the first SuperPoD using near-packaged optics, and roughly double the Atlas 950. The company says it has shipped more than a thousand supernodes to over 370 customers, and TrendForce reports the Ascend 960DT pulled forward three quarters to the first quarter of 2027 — the direct answer to the “Huawei cannot catch up” sceptic this desk ran a fortnight ago.⁴

THE SCEPTIC · THE BENCHMARK SCORES AGAINST TWO OTHER MODELS

The strongest card is methodological, and it is not subtle. TypeSafe built bespoke “workflow evals” rather than running public benchmarks, and scored Jev against the average prediction of GPT-6 Astra and Fable 5.1 — a model-derived reference, not ground truth.³⁴

SOURCES 1 Funding, founders and the launch: BusinessWire (15 Sep); SiliconANGLE; Alwire; typesafe.ai. A reported US\$200m valuation reached us second-hand only and is not printed. The architecture, the typed-answer contract, pricing and the latency claims: typesafe.ai; lilting.ch; Developers Digest. 2 HA-Jev, the MCP server and the repository count: read directly from GitHub, 17 September. The community read: the Hacker News launch thread, with point and comment counts varying by snapshot and printed as such; Latent Space. The self-hoster argument is single-sourced to a low-authority outlet and characterised as circulating. No r/LocalLLaMA thread on the subject could be verified and none is attributed. 3 The evaluation critique and the founder's concession: The Cherry Creek News; agentpedia. The independent test: Mike Taylor, Every. The community head-to-head: iammduncan/typesafe-ai-benchmark, read from GitHub with its author's own caveat carried. 4 Atlas 960 specifications and roadmap: wccftch; StartupTalky; TrendForce on the Ascend 960DT pull-forward. OpenAI's framework and incidents: openai.com; NPR; MarkTechPost. CoreWeave: a Tech Startups roundup, single-sourced.

THE HOME LAB · THE MEMORY BILL IS NOW THE BUILD

The RAM spike did not break. It spread to the graphics cards

A 32-gigabyte DDR5 kit still costs what it cost a fortnight ago. Meanwhile the best street price on an RTX 5090 has gone from US\$4,300 in June to US\$5,199 — and the cause is the same shortage, one component further along.

Take the standing call first, because it needs updating rather than repeating. This desk has been saying buy memory now.¹ Sixty-four gigabytes is where it hurts, because it uses the high-density modules the AI build-out hit hardest: a Corsair Vengeance kit at US\$869.99, a Dominator Titanium at US\$1,274.99, and many desktop lines simply absent.¹

What is new is where it has gone next. The RTX 5090 carries a US\$1,999 list price; the best available American street price in September is US\$5,199, up from US\$4,699.99 in August and US\$4,299.99 in June, and TechPowerUp records graphics prices jumping about fifteen per cent in a single month with the 5090 at 136 per cent above list.¹ The mechanism is a structural GDDR7 shortage. One circulating claim — that memory is now more than eighty per cent of a card's bill of materials — is single-sourced and printed here only as a claim.¹ Stated plainly for a buy-once reader: the 24-gigabyte card already in the machine has appreciated, and the 2026 upgrade path is being priced by memory contracts rather than by silicon.

\$5,199

BEST AVAILABLE US STREET PRICE FOR AN RTX 5090 IN SEPTEMBER, AGAINST A US\$1,999 LIST — UP FROM US\$4,300 IN JUNE.

WHAT ACTUALLY FITS ON 24GB THIS WEEK

Qwen3.8-27B remains the single-card pick. Apache-2.0, released 14 August; this desk's call from a fortnight ago stands and there is no reason to revise it.²

Gemma 4 31B is tight but feasible. Google, released 2 April, Apache 2.0. Google's own quantisation-aware-training

Q4_0 GGUF is 18GB and wants about 20GB at four-bit — 34 at eight-bit, about 71 at bfloat16.²

A useful warning in one line. Qwen3.6-27B's Q4_K_M is 16.8GB — and some conversion packs ship 19.0GB for the same nominal quant.²

THE TOOL WORTH TEN MINUTES: FITUNA

Posted to llama.cpp's show-and-tell on 17 September by a self-described undergraduate, MIT-licensed and installable by pip, FiTuna does the thing everyone does badly by hand: it quantises candidate models, measures perplexity loss against an F16 baseline, benchmarks the survivors, then binary-searches the minimum number of GPU layers that still hits your throughput target inside a quality budget.² The honest caveats: macOS and Linux only for real-hardware runs, single GPU, no tensor split. Useful on a laptop, not yet on a multi-card rig.

THE CHATTER · BUILD THE LOCAL BASELINE FIRST

The argument circulating among self-hosters about this week's launch on the facing page is the right one to end on, and it is not about Jev specifically. *calibrationis* genuinely your bottleneck, or whether a margin threshold is good enough. That is a one-evening experiment on a card whose street price has just doubled, which is the strongest possible argument for running it before you rent the alternative.³

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT A BUY-NOW CALL GETS WRONG

This desk has told the reader to buy memory for several issues, and the honest counter deserves an airing.¹

SOURCES 1 DDR5 pricing on 5 and 11 September, the 64-gigabyte lines and the high-bandwidth-memory reallocation with supply constrained into 2027: WhereIsMyRam's live price chart; Tom's Hardware RAM price index. 2 RTX 5090 street pricing from June to September, the fifteen-per-cent monthly move and the GDDR7 shortage: Tom's Hardware GPU tracker; TechPowerUp. The claim that memory exceeds eighty per cent of a card's bill of materials is single-sourced and flagged in the text. 3 Model sizes, licences and quantised footprints: the Hugging Face repositories for Gemma 4 31B and Qwen3.6-27B; the 4090 throughput figure is a single-source benchmark and the community read is reported sentiment. FiTuna and the llama.cpp release notes: the project's discussion and releases, read from GitHub. The local-baseline argument is one low-authority write-up, characterised as circulating rather than reported.

GEAR WE'RE WATCHING · CANON EOS R8 MARK II

Four hundred dollars buys a stabiliser, a joystick and a card slot you can reach — and the same sensor as 2023

Announced on Tuesday with reviews landing inside a day, Canon's cheapest full-frame body finally has stabilisation in it.

this story  

Canon announced the EOS R8 Mark II on Tuesday 15 September, opened pre-orders the same day, and had full independent reviews on the internet within twenty-four hours — which tells you the review samples went out weeks ago. **S\$2,519 body and S\$2,859 kit**, on sale locally in October.¹

What is new, in one sentence: four hundred dollars over the outgoing R8 buys five-axis in-body stabilisation rated to 7.5 stops centre-frame and 7 at the periphery, an autofocus joystick the old camera lacked, Wi-Fi 6, a buffer thirty per cent deeper in RAW and fifty-eight per cent in JPEG, a card slot moved out of the battery compartment to the grip side so it is reachable on a tripod, and a new body.¹ Elsewhere: forty frames a second on the electronic shutter to as many as 190 JPEGs, pre-capture, six-K-oversampled uncropped 4K/60p in ten-bit with Canon Log 3, uncropped Full HD to 180p, Dual Pixel CMOS AF II with people, animal and vehicle detection, a single UHS-II slot, and weather sealing.¹ Canon briefed the 1980s T80 as the styling cue and shot its own press images next to an EOS 650.

S\$2,519

SINGAPORE BODY PRICE, CONFIRMED BY CANON SINGAPORE — WHICH MAKES THIS THE CHEAPEST ROUTE TO A STABILISED FULL-FRAME CANON THAT HAS EVER EXISTED LOCALLY

The reviews are the useful part, because they agree with each other and with the complaint. *DPR* review's headline is the verdict: new design, major fixes, but frustrations remain. It praises the R3-and-R1-style grip material and the low-profile viewfinder hump, calls the relocated card slot a genuine usability win, and singles out the electronic viewfinder — the same 0.39-inch, 2.36-million-dot panel as before — as

slightly disappointing.¹ *PetaPixel* called it a great camera in a polarising package, judging that the new face will ruffle feathers while the usability and performance gains are excellent. *Amateur Photographer*: Canon's entry-level full-frame camera finally grows up.

THE CHATTER · THE REVIEWERS LIKE IT, THE FORUM DOES NOT

The flagship thread on the *DPR* review forums is titled, in capitals, "CANON R8 II — DOA," and runs to at least a third page. *look*: posters calling it dead on arrival as expected, or an R6 Mark II in lighter clothing with an ugly design, or an ugly duckling whose design language reads far more Sony than Canon.²

THE SCEPTIC · ONE SLOT, ONE VIEWFINDER, ONE SENSOR

Three objections and they are all fair. **Still one card slot**, carried over, and the direct competitor — Nikon's Z5 II — has two; the redundancy argument is not theoretical for anyone shooting paid work. **The viewfinder did not move**: the same 0.39-inch, 2.36-million-dot panel as a 2023 camera, in a body now four hundred dollars dearer, and *DPR* says so in its own words. **And the imaging pipeline is three and a half years old** — same sensor, same processor; the upgrade is mechanical and ergonomic.

STILL ON THE SHELF

Sonos Ace Ultra — the Singapore price landed, the reviews did not. S\$699 in Black, White, Agave and Sand, general availability 29 September, pre-orders having run from 2 September at TC Acoustic and the Sonos store at Wheelock Place. As of the 17th there is still no measurement-based review anywhere — *What Hi-Fi*'s piece remains an IFA hands-on with the verdict explicitly pending. For context the same headphone is US\$449, £399 and AU\$699, so S\$699 is a notably firm local mark-up, and until somebody measures it the mark-up is the only reviewable fact about it.²

SOURCES 1 Announcement, pre-orders, shipping, US and Singapore prices and the full specification: Canon USA's newsroom and Canon Singapore's own release, both primary; Tech Edition for the Singapore prices; Newsshooter; CineD; Notebookcheck; Camera Jabber; GlobeNewswire. UK pricing could not be verified and is not printed. 2 Reviews and the design objections: *DPR*; *PetaPixel*; *Amateur Photographer*; *TechRadar*; *Digital Camera World*; The Phoblographer on the renders; Canon Rumors. Reviewer names and any numeric score could not be verified and are not printed, so the quoted phrasings are headline and summary lines; the forum sentiment is from the *DPR* thread, characterised in our own words. Sonos Ace Ultra Singapore pricing and availability: HardwareZone Singapore, with *What Hi-Fi* for the still-pending hands-on.

OBJECTS & ESCAPES · MCINTOSH CS7500

Twelve and a half thousand dollars for one box instead of four — and the trade press says so out loud

McIntosh has folded a preamplifier, a network streamer, a DAC, a phono stage and a headphone amp into a single chassis with the blue meters on the front.

this story  

Anounced on 26 August in Binghamton, New York, and available from that day through authorised dealers, the CS7500 does something McIntosh has resisted for a long time: it consolidates.¹

The craft is where the money visibly goes, and it is worth describing precisely because it is the argument.¹ There is no Singapore price in any public source and this page will not invent one; the local route is Ong Radio, McIntosh's distributor here, on a relationship reported at more than seventy years.¹

5 boxes → 1

PREAMP, STREAMER, DAC, PHONO STAGE AND HEADPHONE AMP IN ONE CHASSIS. GRAMOPHONE'S FRAMING: LESS SPACE AND SIMPLER THAN SEPARATES — JUST ADD A POWER AMPLIFIER AND SPEAKERS

WHAT YOU ARE ACTUALLY PAYING FOR

Not the silicon. The digital board and the streaming platform are conventional parts, and the coverage concedes as much: multiple outlets frame the CS7500 explicitly as not McIntosh's answer to WiiM, Eversolo, NAD or FiiO — which is another way of saying the streaming-and-conversion function is available for a small fraction of the price.² What the money buys is metalwork and channel: two different stainless finishes, machined end caps, glass, the meters, and the luxury-dealer margin. What it buys functionally is consolidation — one box, one power cord, six analogue inputs and an ARC connection for

the television, with resale-proof brand equity as the sweetener. That is a real thing to want.

THE CHATTER · THE MOST RELIABLY POLARISING NAME IN HI-FI

The split around this brand is structural rather than product-specific, and you can read it in the titles of the threads people start. Audiogon asks, flatly, why some audiophiles “beat up” McIntosh.²

THE SCEPTIC · A NAMED CEILING, FROM A NAMED REVIEWER

Gramophone, reviewing it, supplies the diminishing-returns line better than any forum could. The McIntosh sound is clear and detailed but also smooth — and the C49 preamplifier the CS7500 is built on cannot quite equal the C12000, the company's own twin-chassis flagship at around nineteen thousand dollars; it offers a lot of what that product does.³ Two things follow. Second, and more useful to a buyer: the CS7500 is an existing preamplifier with a streaming board added, not a clean-sheet design — which is exactly what makes the consolidation cheap to engineer and the price hard to justify on parts. *What Hi-Fi* put the rest of it in its own headline: classic looks, streaming smarts, and a premium price tag.³

STILL ON THE SHELF

Klipsch Reference Premiere III — nine passive models built around a new high-density axial Tractrix horn tweeter, flush-mounted to cut wave breakup and widen the off-axis response, with copper Cerametallic woofers on new metal outrigger feet.³

SOURCES 1 Announcement date and availability, price, inputs, digital formats, distortion and signal-to-noise figures and the chassis materials: McIntosh Laboratory's own product page, primary; *The Absolute Sound*; *What Hi-Fi*; ecoustics; StereoNET. The blue-meter lineage: *Robb Report*. 2 Singapore distribution through Ong Radio: pt.AUDIO. No Singapore price exists in public sources and none is printed. The WiiM, Eversolo, NAD and FiiO framing comes from the launch coverage above. 3 Community sentiment is reported only as the existence and framing of threads on Audiogon, Audio Science Review and AVS Forum; none could be opened this week, so no comment is quoted and no individual position characterised. The named review ceiling, the C49 basis and the C12000 comparison: *Gramophone*; the price-tag line is *What Hi-Fi*'s own headline. Klipsch Reference Premiere III: StereoNET; Gear Patrol; the Klipsch newsroom.

CULTURE DESK · TWO CYBERPUNKS OPEN TODAY

The best-reviewed video-game adaptation ever recorded opens on the same Friday as a thirty-year-old masterpiece in four K

Zach Cregger's *Resident Evil* is in theatres and IMAX from today with a Rotten Tomatoes score in the high nineties and no audience score at all. Lionsgate is putting *Ghost in the Shell* back into eight hundred North American cinemas the same day. One bill, two arguments about what an adaptation owes its source.

this story 

Sony puts *Resident Evil* into theatres and IMAX today. Zach Cregger directs; Austin Abrams plays Bryan, a medical courier caught in an outbreak while making a delivery to Raccoon City General Hospital, with Zach Cherry, Kali Reis and Paul Walter Hauser.¹ Reviews landed around 16 September and the consensus claim across outlets is that it is the best-reviewed video-game adaptation Rotten Tomatoes has ever recorded.¹ There is no audience score, because until today there has been no audience.

The same Friday, Lionsgate returns Mamoru Oshii's *Ghost in the Shell* to more than eight hundred North American cinemas, in four K in selected houses, with a new trailer and poster and tickets already on sale at announcement.²

800+

NORTH AMERICAN SCREENS TAKING A 1995 JAPANESE ANIMATED FILM BACK FOR ITS THIRTIETH ANNIVERSARY — ON THE SAME DAY AS THE YEAR'S BEST-REVIEWED GAME ADAPTATION

The accidental double bill is the story, because the two films answer the same question in opposite directions. *Resident Evil* story at all. He has been publicly adamant about not remaking a narrative from the games, answering objectors that he is not breaking the rules of the games, calling himself the biggest worshipper of them, and framing the film as a love letter.³ Fidelity to the plot, or fidelity to the feeling: thirty years apart, and both are in cinemas tonight.

THE CHATTER · A FANBASE THAT SPLIT BEFORE ANYONE SAW IT

The reaction here is fan-side rather than critic-side, and it ran ahead of the film. The game fanbase divided between purists angry at a non-adaptation and a larger camp reassured once the reviews arrived; coverage characterises the objectors as a small but attention-starved contingent making pre-emptive complaints, and Cregger's public reply — the love-letter line — functioned as the pressure valve.³

THE SCEPTIC · A RECORD ANNOUNCED AT THREE DIFFERENT NUMBERS

The honest attack is not on the film, which nobody outside the press has seen. An all-time record was published on 16 September at ninety-six, ninety-seven and ninety-eight per cent by different outlets, drawn from an opening-week sample of around seventy reviews, with no audience score in existence and general release not yet begun. *DiscussingFilm*'s brutal-and-darkly-hilarious framing and a positive *IndieWire*. The falsifier, then, rather than a dissenter: if the score slides materially as the sample widens past a hundred reviews, or if the audience number opens well below the critics', the record was a small-sample artefact.⁴

IN BRIEF

A24's *Primetime* is still 25 September, unmoved. Lance Oppenheim directs, Ajon Singh writes; Robert Pattinson stars and produces as Chris Hansen around 2006 making *To Catch a Predator*, with Merritt Wever, Skyler Gisondo and Phoebe Bridgers. It premiered in main competition at Venice on 5 September in Golden Lion contention. No box office, because it is unreleased. A single-sourced headline claiming it has set a Rotten Tomatoes record is not printed here.⁴

SOURCES 1 Release, cast, premise and the three conflicting review percentages: Rotten Tomatoes editorial; *IndieWire*; *SlashFilm*; *ScreenRant*; *Variety* for the release date. No audience score existed at press time. 2 *The Ghost in the Shell* 4K re-release, its screen count and ticketing: *Gizmodo*; *ComingSoon*. The 1995 release date is the film's own. 3 Cregger's position on not adapting an existing story, and the fan reaction: *IGN* and the launch coverage, reported as secondary characterisation of sentiment rather than a read of any forum. No named negative review was found and none is invented; the falsification test is ours. 4 *Primetime*: *Deadline*; *Gold Derby*. *Oldman on Bond*: *Deadline*. Festival dates: the San Sebastián and Toronto official calendars. Box office for 11–13 September: *Film+Book*; *Box Office Mojo*; *The Numbers* — the domestic-against-worldwide ambiguity is flagged in the text. The *Billboard* 200 reached this desk through a search layer rather than from *Billboard* directly.

RAISING THEM WELL · THE FINNISH COHORT, READ PROPERLY

More screen time through childhood, slightly faster thinking at sixteen — and a second finding nobody reported

A Finnish cohort followed 260 children for eight years and found that accumulating more screen time tracked with marginally better cognitive processing. *less unsupervised physical activity did the same — which is the half that tells you what the study is probably measuring.*

this story 

The paper is Jalanko and colleagues, “Associations of Physical Activity and Sedentary Time From Childhood to Adolescence With Cognition in Adolescence: The PANIC Study,” in *Pediatric Exercise Science*, 2026, volume 38 issue 3, page 268, out of the University of Jyväskylä and the University of Eastern Finland.¹ It followed 260 adolescents — 124 girls, 136 boys — measuring physical activity and sedentary time at baseline, at two years and at eight, and assessing cognition with the CogState battery once, at the eight-year examination, when participants were fifteen to seventeen with a mean age of 15.8.¹

Be precise about what that means for a household with a Secondary One child, because the coverage was not *accumulation* of habits across those years showing up later — not a measurement of twelve-year-olds.

The numbers. Cumulative self-reported screen time was inversely associated with reaction time — faster responses — at a standardised beta of -0.194 in both working-memory tasks, and directly associated with overall cognition at beta 0.187 , interval 0.070 to 0.305 .¹ Both intervals clear zero, and both lower bounds sit close to it.

$\beta = 0.19$

THE SCREEN-TIME-TO-COGNITION ASSOCIATION.
DIRECTION SURPRISING, SIZE SMALL — AND MEASURED
ONCE, AT A MEAN AGE OF FIFTEEN POINT EIGHT, IN 260
FINNISH CHILDREN

Now the half that was dropped. The authors’ own statement of the result is that accumulating *less unsupervised physical activity* and more screen time from childhood to adolescence was associated with better cognition.

Their own stated limitations are unusually candid. Cognition was assessed only at the eight-year examination, so full longitudinal modelling of activity against cognition was not possible, and they call for studies that repeatedly assess cognition rather than only exposure.¹ Their own framing in coverage was that we should not regard screen time as solely harmful — with the explicit caveat that this is association, not proof, and more nuanced than “more screens is good.”

THE CHATTER · SINGAPORE PARENTS WANTED THE RULES

The useful local read comes from an education-research institution rather than a forum, which means it can be cited without laundering anonymous posts. *South China Morning Post*’s headline on the same shift was “better late than never.” That cuts against the assumption that Singapore parents resent device rules; mostly they wanted them.²

THE SCEPTIC · THE SAME FINNISH GROUP, AGAINST ITSELF

Skip the imported methodologists; the sharpest objection comes from the researchers’ own institutions.² So: more screen time tracks with better cognitive processing *and* worse mental health.³

SOURCES 1 Jalanko, Leppänen, Bond, Laukkanen, Lakka and Haapala (2026), *Pediatric Exercise Science* 38(3):268, DOI 10.1123/pes.2025-0083, PubMed 42214695; the open medRxiv preprint; the University of Jyväskylä press release. Sample, ages, design, effect sizes, confidence intervals, the sex split and the unsupervised-activity coefficient are all from the paper and its release. 2 The authors’ stated limitations and the self-report caveat: as above, with PsyPost and Technology Networks for the “slightly better” framing. 3 Parental sentiment: the National Institute of Education at NTU Singapore, and the *South China Morning Post* — characterised in our own words; Reddit and KiasuParents were unreachable this week and nothing is attributed to them. The companion finding on screen time and mental health: University of Eastern Finland and University of Jyväskylä releases of March 2025; Yle. Odgers via *Scientific American*, and Orben and Przybylski in *Psychological Science* (2019) — both about social media and wellbeing rather than this study, and cited only for effect-size context. **General guidance, not medical advice.**

THE TWEEN YEARS • THE HALF-HOUR NOBODY ANNOUNCED

The device ban got the headlines. The lever was thirty minutes of bedtime

Singapore's secondary-school phone restrictions took effect in January and were widely reported. Buried in the same release: the default sleep hours on school-issued learning devices moved from eleven o'clock to half past ten — a concrete, dateable half-hour taken off a Secondary One night.

The Ministry of Education's announcement of 30 November 2025 did two things, and the smaller one is more likely to matter. The headline measure: from January 2026 secondary students may not use smartphones or smartwatches during school hours — and the release is explicit that this includes recess, co-curricular activities, and supplementary, enrichment and remedial lessons.¹ The quieter measure: the default sleep hours in the device-management application on school Personal Learning Devices shifted from 11.00pm to 10.30pm.¹

The ministry's own rationale names the mechanism this desk keeps returning to: screen use displaces sleep, physical activity and in-person social interaction, and is linked to poorer holistic wellbeing. The measures sit under the Grow Well SG strategy, and a parliamentary reply of 13 January 2026 set out the secondary-school position in full.¹ Note what the second measure is, structurally. It is not a rule the child has to keep, a teacher has to police or a parent has to argue about at ten at night. It is a default, changed centrally, on a device the school owns.

10.30pm

THE NEW DEFAULT SLEEP CUTOFF ON SCHOOL-ISSUED PERSONAL LEARNING DEVICES, DOWN FROM ELEVEN — THE MOST CONSEQUENTIAL HALF-HOUR IN THE WHOLE JANUARY PACKAGE, AND THE ONE NOBODY COVERED

THE VERY SINGAPORE ITEM: EYES, NOT SCREENS

There is a longer-running programme here worth knowing about in a household with a twelve-year-old, because it predates every current argument. The Health Promotion Board and the Ministry of Education have run the National Myopia Prevention Programme since 2001, aiming to delay onset and slow progression through public education and

vision screening, and the health ministry has published on the effectiveness of its strategies for primary-school students.² A quarter-century of it is why Singapore has screening infrastructure that most countries arguing about screen time do not, and why the local conversation about near-work has always had an ophthalmic half as well as a psychological one.

STILL ON THE SHELF

The Australian under-sixteen social-media ban's first evaluation — use falling only from 86 to 82 per cent, no drop at the cutoff age, fifteen to nineteen per cent of accounts fake, and parental awareness actually declining — ran on this desk yesterday and has no new peg. One line, not a second outing.

THE CHATTER • A USEFUL FOREIGN COMPARISON

For a household weighing whether school phone rules are worth the friction, the closest thing to a clean read comes from a Brookings survey in the United States finding that parents *and* teens support school cellphone bans and that most do not perceive major downsides. Different country, different school system, and offered only as contrast to the Singapore picture on the facing page — where the support is similar and the scepticism is about enforcement rather than principle.³

THE SCEPTIC • A DEFAULT IS NOT AN OUTCOME

Two honest limits on the enthusiasm above. First, a device-management sleep window governs one device. A Secondary One student with a personal phone, a sibling's tablet or a games console has not been sent to bed by a policy change on a school laptop, and no published evaluation yet shows whether the thirty minutes converts into thirty minutes of sleep.

SOURCES 1 The scope of the restriction, including recess and co-curricular activities, and the change of default device sleep hours from eleven to half past ten from January 2026, with the Grow Well SG framing: Ministry of Education press release of 30 November 2025, primary. 2 The parliamentary reply of 13 January 2026 on the secondary-school position: Ministry of Education. The National Myopia Prevention Programme since 2001 and the published assessment of its strategies: Health Promotion Board and Ministry of Education; Ministry of Health newsroom. 3 The Brookings survey on parental and teen support for school cellphone bans, offered as a foreign comparison only. Items referenced in a single line are from this desk's own recent editions. **General guidance, not medical advice.**

THE BIG PICTURE • THE DAY AFTER

The Fed hiked into an oil shock, and the bond market said thank you

Wednesday punished everything: a nineteen-year high in the ten-year, a dollar through 100, gold down a hundred and twenty-six dollars in hours.

this story 

Yields fell. On Thursday, the day after the Federal Reserve delivered its first rate rise since July 2023, the ten-year Treasury yield dropped more than five basis points to 4.951 per cent, the thirty-year more than five to 5.297, the two-year more than three to 4.692.¹ A central bank had just raised the price of money into a war-driven oil shock, lifted its median end-2026 projection to 4.1 per cent from 3.8, and penciled in no cuts through 2027 — and the long end came down.¹ CNBC's explanation is the right one: investors grew more confident precisely because the Fed had begun a cycle against inflation that will not fall on its own.

Read the two days as one sentence with a comma in it. Wednesday, the decision: the ten-year at 5.02 per cent and a nineteen-year high, the dollar through 100 for the first time in nearly seven weeks, gold spiking to US\$4,366 then collapsing to US\$4,240, equities rattled.¹ Thursday, the digestion: the whole curve rallying, the dollar flat at 100.23, gold up a full one per cent to about US\$4,307, jobless claims at 196,000 against 208,000 expected, the Straits Times Index up half a per cent.¹ This is a credibility rally — a committee buying back the long end by proving it will hurt.¹

THE LEVELS • THURSDAY 17 SEPTEMBER

INSTRUMENT	LEVEL	MOVE
US 10-year	4.951%	▼ -5bp
US 30-year	5.297%	▼ -5bp
DXY (dollar)	100.23	— flat
USD/SGD	1.2771	▼ SGD softer
USD/JPY	~156	▲ into the BoJ
Gold (spot /oz)	\$4,307	▲ +1.0%
Bitcoin	\$76,357	— flat through

SOURCES 1 Thursday's yields across the curve and the easing in mortgage rates: CNBC, corroborated independently by TradingEconomics; Yahoo Personal Finance. 2 The decision, unanimity, the median dot lifted to 4.1 per cent, no cuts through 2027, the roughly ninety-three-per-cent pricing, market expectations of further rises, and Wednesday's decision-day prints: Fortune; CNN; Benzinga; American Banker; Saxo. Thursday's flat dollar, USD/SGD, USD/JPY, the Straits Times Index and the pending Bank of Japan decision: TradingEconomics; Yahoo Finance Singapore, single-sourced on USD/SGD; the Bank of Japan release calendar. USD/JPY's daily change could not be verified and is not printed. 3 Gold's Thursday level and one-per-cent gain via TradingEconomics, cross-checked against TradingView and Kitco; Wednesday's path and the real-yield mechanism via Saxo and goldsilver.com; second-quarter official buying via the World Gold Council. Bitcoin: Saxo; CoinDesk, including the 2022 echo. Jobless claims: FXStreet; Bloomberg; the US Department of Labor. Dissent: Goldman Sachs economists and Michael Pearce of Oxford Economics via CNN; Peter Navarro via the *Washington Times*; Axios on internal caution. A single source's claim of a far higher all-time gold high is irreconcilable with every other print and is omitted. **Market explanation, not investment advice; unverifiable levels are held, never invented.**

Brent crude	\$104.82	▼ -\$1.01
STI	5,660.52	▲ +0.5%
VWRA (All-World)	\$191.50	— 16 Sep, held

VWRA carried as held — no Thursday close was obtainable.

US\$126

WHAT AN OUNCE OF GOLD LOST ON DECISION DAY, FROM US\$4,366 TO US\$4,240 — THEN TOOK BACK, AND A FULL ONE PER CENT MORE, THE NEXT SESSION WHILE THE DOLLAR SAT STILL

Name the regime: higher-for-longer, credibility restored. The dollar made its whole move on the decision and then stopped dead, leaving USD/SGD at 1.2771 and the yen near 156 as the Bank of Japan sat down to a meeting whose answer lands hours after this page.¹ The Fed cannot reach the oil price doing the inflating (p3).²

The Fed cannot reach the oil price doing the inflating. It can still reach the market's belief about itself — and this week it did.

WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD & BTC

Take the two days separately, because they answer the diversification question in opposite directions.³

THE SCEPTIC • BROAD, NAMED, AND SELF-CONTRADICTING

The objection is not fringe. Goldman Sachs economists argued the case for hiking was weak: the economy was not overheating, demand was not excessive, and the supply shocks driving inflation would correct once the war ended.³ The distributional point is sharpest: the hike slows housing and barely touches AI capital spending.³

DOWN THE RABBIT HOLE · MODEL ROCKETRY

The alphabet is a logarithmic scale, and the law draws its line at one hundred and sixty newton-seconds

Every letter in a rocket-motor code doubles the one before it, so the gap from an A to an M is a factor of about four thousand.

this story  

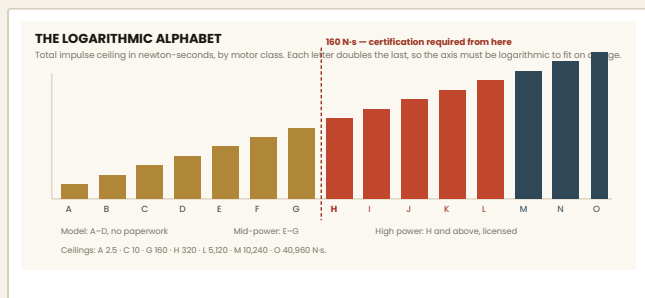
Model rocketry in 2026 is three hobbies wearing one name, and what separates them is not taste but a certification ladder and a statute. **total impulse** in newton-seconds, and each letter step *doubles the ceiling* of the one before it. An A runs 1.26 to 2.50 newton-seconds. A C is 5.01 to 10. An H is 160.01 to 320.¹ So an M is not “a bit more than an L,” and the distance from A to M is a factor of roughly four thousand.¹

The practical tiers follow from the numbers. **Model rocketry** is roughly A to D — cardboard tube, balsa or plastic fins, a black-powder motor, no certification and no paperwork. **Mid-power** is roughly E to G on 24- and 29-millimetre motors, still with no certification required, and it is where serious adults live who do not want the waiver problem.

THE LADDER, AND THE RUNG THAT IS A THESIS DEFENCE

×4,000

THE IMPULSE RATIO FROM AN A MOTOR TO AN M —
BECAUSE EVERY LETTER DOUBLES THE LAST. THIRTEEN
LETTERS, FOUR THOUSAND TIMES THE ENERGY



Thirteen letters, four thousand times the energy. The dashed line at 160 newton-seconds is where the hobby stops being a hobby: you cannot buy or fly an H motor without certification.

THE SCALE OF THE WORLD, AND A GENUINE SURPRISE IN IT

The National Association of Rocketry has more than nine thousand members and about 250 affiliated sections, and describes itself as the oldest and largest hobby rocketry organisation in the world.² Tripoli is the international body for high power, and its local clubs are called *prefectures*— a genuinely odd piece of jargon for a hobby about cardboard tubes. Its current membership number could not be verified and none is printed.²

And now the fact worth taking to dinner. **Estes is a family business.** The Langford family — John, Ellis, Fritz and Mallory — bought Estes out of the collapsing Hobbico in April 2018, with Mallory Langford as president and Ellis Langford as chief technology officer.² Then the twist: Estes spun out a solid-propellant arm, Estes Energetics, in 2021 — and in November 2025 Estes Energetics was acquired by Voyager Technologies, listed on the New York Stock Exchange.² The cardboard-tube toy company from Penrose, Colorado now has a sibling inside a public space-defence firm.³ That no credible independent number exists is itself the fact about how small and unwatched this business is.

How people fall in has changed, and the evidence is commercial rather than anecdotal.

SOURCES 1 Impulse classes and the doubling rule, corroborated across three independent sources: the standard classification tables as published by UKRA's safety code and the National Association of Rocketry's standards and testing committee, cross-checked against the general reference. The number-letter-number designation is universal community usage and is printed as held. 2 The 160 newton-second high-power threshold and the Level 1, 2 and 3 requirements, including the three-flight log and the in-process design and construction reviews: National Association of Rocketry high-power certification pages; Tripoli Rocketry Association certification pages. Fee schedules were unreachable and no cost figure is printed. NAR membership and section count: the association's own pages. Tripoli's prefectures: tripoli.org; its membership figure could not be verified. Subreddit and Discord counts: a third-party analytics aggregator and the Discord invites, single-sourced and attributed as such. 3 The Langford family's purchase of Estes from Hobbico in April 2018: estesrockets.com; Lincoln International. Estes Energetics spun out in 2021 and acquired by Voyager Technologies in November 2025: SpaceNews; KAL Capital Markets. The two irreconcilable market estimates: The Business Research Company and Business Research Insights — neither is printed as a figure. Estes' education arm and the Xyla Foxlin signature line: edu.estesrockets.com; eRockets; her own site.

THE DEEP END · THE GEAR, AND THE SHIPPING FEE THAT SHAPES IT

Two motor systems with opposite cost curves — and a hazmat charge levied per box, not per motor

Aerotech cases cost more and the reloads cost less. Cesaroni is the reverse, and its reloads arrive with both closures fitted so there is nothing to assemble wrongly.

The community that receives newcomers is a forum that outlived the forum age. **The Rocketry Forum** is the centre of gravity for the English-speaking hobby, segmented by power level and by topic, with sections covering single-use black powder, composite reloads and hybrids.¹ Around it: r/rocketry and its Discord, **Australian Rocketry** (the nearest anglophone community to Singapore by timezone), **RocketReviews** as a kit and motor archive, and **ThrustCurve**, the open motor-performance database every simulation pulls from.¹

Four people matter disproportionately. **Joe Barnard of BPS.space** is the most consequential individual in modern amateur rocketry: after years of iteration he achieved propulsive landing of a model rocket with his Scoutvehicle, which required three things nobody sells off the shelf — thrust vector control, throttle control of a solid motor, and bespoke flight software.¹ **Xyla Foxlin**, a mechatronics engineer with over half a million subscribers and more than thirty-five million views, developed a high-power kit aimed specifically at Level 1 and Level 2 certification flights — she is the bridge between YouTube and the ladder.¹ **Tim Van Milligan at Apogee Components** publishes “Peak of Flight,” a free newsletter deep into its 670s and the closest thing the hobby has to a journal of record.¹ And **Integza**, at 1.73 million subscribers, is an *engine* channel rather than a rocketry one — not in the NAR or Tripoli world at all.

THE ARGUMENT THAT IS REALLY ABOUT RELIABILITY

Black powder versus composite is not a taste war, and the community’s own explanation is specific: composite motors are harder to over-pressurise than Estes black powder, because the larger and longer black-powder slugs are more susceptible to fracture from temperature cycling and the occasional drop — and a cracked grain is a bomb.² Which is why the Estes E is a live, documented grievance rather than a grumble. One flier posting to the forum reported a second catastrophic failure within his last ten launches — a twenty-per-cent rate — and switched to single-use Aerotech, reasoning explicitly that the higher motor cost is justified once you price in replacing destroyed rockets.²

THE GEAR, WEIGHTED TO THE TIERS THAT LAST

\$80–\$120

THE HAZMAT SURCHARGE ON A MOTOR SHIPMENT — PER BOX, NOT PER MOTOR, ON A STATED 2025 VENDOR FEE OF US\$54 PLUS SHIPPING. WHICH IS WHY THIS HOBBY BUYS IN GROUP ORDERS, AND WHY THE ELEVENTH MOTOR EFFECTIVELY SHIPS FREE

That surcharge is the most-complained-about number in the hobby, and it has a threshold that changes a buying decision permanently.³ The consequence, though, is the best purchasing insight on the page: **staying at or below G is not only a certification decision, it is a shipping decision.** Crossing into H restructures your per-order cost for good. Apogee’s own policy detail underlines it — its store credit on hazmat shipments covers half the weight-based cost and explicitly excludes the hazmat fee itself.³

SOURCES 1 The Rocketry Forum’s structure, depth and moderated hot-topics instruction; Australian Rocketry; RocketReviews; ThrustCurve — all verified to exist, with ThrustCurve’s motor count unread and none printed. Joe Barnard’s propulsive landing and the thrust-vector-control specification: bps.space documentation; Hackaday; Make. The date could not be pinned inside the last twelve months and none is claimed. Xyla Foxlin’s figures and certification kit: her own site. “Peak of Flight” issue numbering: Apogee Components. Integza’s subscriber count: NetInfluencer; community regard could not be verified and is not characterised. 2 The composite-against-black-powder reliability mechanism and the Estes E complaints: Rocketry Forum threads on motor comparison, a second catastrophic failure and continued Estes E use; an Australian Rocketry thread on E-motor reliability. Estes Pro Series II launch rail, pad and controller prices and the Star Orbiter and Leviathan: Apogee Components; Sirius Rocketry; estesrockets.com; Hobbylinc — kit prices were not captured. 3 Mid- and high-tier makers and prices: Madcow Rocketry; Wildman Rocketry; eRockets for LOC listings. Binder Design’s trading status and Performance Rocketry’s line could not be verified and neither is asserted. Motor hardware pricing and the opposed cost curves: aerotech-rocketry.com; Rocketarium; Sirius Rocketry; Apogee; and Rocketry Forum comparison threads for the community framing and the self-attributed assembly failures. The hazmat surcharge rests on one vendor’s stated 2025 fee; the G-and-below shipping threshold and the propellant-mass figure are community claims not traced to a primary regulatory source and are printed as held; Apogee’s shipping policy is its own. **Prices were read on 17 September from search-surfaced retailer listings rather than confirmed on live product pages, and are printed as reported.**

THE DEEP END • THE ELECTRONICS, THE WORDS, AND THE CUSTOMS DESK

The best object in the hobby is a rubber band that knows how high it is

Jolly Logic's Chute Release is not an altimeter. It holds a packed parachute shut and lets go at a set height, which buys you low-drift recovery with no ejection charge, no electronics bay and no black powder.

Electronics is this reader's natural door, and the best object in it computes nothing about your flight.

Then the kits you solder, where this hobby meets the home lab. **Eggtimer** runs from about US\$15 for the Apogee through US\$40 for the WiFi-configurable Quantum to US\$90 for the GPS-telemetry TRS — figures this desk flags as **stale**, because they trace to the maker's own 2021 sheet and a second source quotes the TRS at US\$140.¹ At the connoisseur end **Altus Metrum** is open-source with published manuals: EasyMini US\$80, TeleGPS US\$200, TeleMetrum US\$300.

THE VOCABULARY — AND A DISPUTED ETYMOLOGY

CATO — the motor over-pressurises, destroying case, nozzle and closure and often taking the rocket with it. Nobody is sure what it stands for: either an acronym for “catastrophe at take-off” or simply a contraction of *catastrophic*. A hobby whose worst word has a contested origin.

THE CALENDAR IS THE FACTION MAP

You can read the subcultures off the events without asserting a single opinion. **NARAM** is a competition meet under the NAR's national rules; NARAM-67 ran at Muncie, Indiana, in late June.²

THE CHATTER • THE CUTTING EDGE IS A DOWNLOAD

Ask what is state of the art and the honest answer beats the hype. Barnard's propulsive landing is the defining technical achievement of amateur rocketry, and *Make*:has run the headline “build your own thrust-vectorated rockets for vertical landings like SpaceX” — which is why newcomers arrive wanting to land a booster before they can glue a fin straight.**3D files.**

THE SCEPTIC • THE SINGAPORE PROBLEM, STATED HONESTLY

This desk cannot tell you that flying a rocket motor in Singapore is legal, and the evidence suggests the reader will not fly here.**Whether a private individual here can lawfully obtain a licence to import, store or use hobby motors could not be verified from a primary source, and no licence cost, route or processing time appears on this page because none could be confirmed.** Nor could any local club or regional flying site — and none is invented.*Esquire Singapore*published “Launching a Locally-Made Rocket Outside Singapore.” The Singapore Propulsion Lab took third place at an international competition in 2023, the first successful launch and recovery of a rocket designed entirely by a Singaporean student group, after a last-minute scramble over US customs.³ So the defensible path: simulation and electronics at home — OpenRocket is free, and a twelve-year-old can watch the trajectory change as she drags a fin — and a club launch abroad as the flying holiday.⁴

NEXT DESCENTS • YOU PICK NO. 107

Urban sketching & watercolour — the lowest kit cost and the steepest skill curve in the book.

Home cheesemaking — cultures, rennet and a cave in a wine fridge, in a country at eighty per cent humidity.

Knife making / bladesmithing — heat treatment is the whole craft; everything before it is shaping.

SOURCES 1 Electronics and prices: jollylogic.com; eggtimerrocketry.com and its 2021 comparison sheet, flagged stale in the text with the conflicting quote noted; csrocketry.com and altusmetrum.org for Altus Metrum; MAC Performance Rocketry for Missile Works. The AltimeterThree price could not be captured. 2 The recurring altimeter question and the StratoLogger availability threads: The Rocketry Forum. Glossary definitions: the community's own published glossaries at RocketReviews and RocketMime, a club terms document, and the forum's glossary thread; terms this desk could not verify are omitted rather than defined from memory. 3 Event dates: Tripoli for LDRS 44 and for BALLS 34, branded a Research Launch with registration announced open; the National Association of Rocketry and the Academy of Model Aeronautics for NARAM-67; QC Rocketry for Midwest Power. How a launch day runs step by step could not be verified and is not described. The cutting edge: bps.space's own product listing, RocketReviews on Signal Alpha and *Make*: for the headline; the custom-tier finding from Rocketry Forum nose-cone and custom-design threads. No lead time, deposit or waitlist could be verified and none is printed. 4 Singapore: the Guns, Explosives and Weapons Control Act 2021, operationalised on 1 July 2025, and the division's remit, via the Singapore Police Force's licensing overview; the statutory definition was read through a search synthesis of the statute and is printed as indicated rather than verified; airspace from the Civil Aviation Authority of Singapore's own pages. The student scene: the Singapore Rocketry Club and SEDS Singapore. The 2023 competition result and the customs scramble: *Esquire Singapore*; The Online Citizen; Asia News Network. OpenRocket v24.12: openrocket.info.

THE LONG GAME · WHEN THE PRESS RELEASE OVERSELLS THE PAPER

“You need 560 minutes a week” — and an Oxford professor who says that is not what the study found

A large UK Biobank analysis put substantial cardiovascular benefit at three to four times current guidance.

this story  

Start with the study, because it is a good one. Liang and colleagues, in the *British Journal of Sports Medicine*, modelled device-measured physical activity and cardiorespiratory fitness jointly against incident cardiovascular disease in 17,088 UK Biobank participants — mean age fifty-seven, ninety-six per cent white — using a cohort design plus Mendelian randomisation, a genuine strength for causal inference.¹

The findings, in order of usefulness. A hundred and fifty minutes a week associated with eight to nine per cent lower cardiovascular risk.¹ And the part built for an optimiser: the dose is fitness-dependent.

150 vs 560

MINUTES A WEEK FOR EIGHT TO NINE PER CENT LOWER CARDIOVASCULAR RISK, AGAINST MORE THAN THIRTY PER CENT.

Then the rebuttal, and it is unusually blunt for an institutional channel. Professor Aiden Doherty, professor of biomedical informatics at the University of Oxford, via the UK Science Media Centre: “The press release does not accurately reflect the science in the paper.”

THE SECOND ITEM: TRAINING WITH THE CLOCK, NOT AGAINST IT

The more directly actionable finding is smaller and newer in design terms. A twelve-week randomised controlled trial in *Open Heart*, published 14 April 2026, took 150 sedentary adults aged forty to sixty in Lahore, Pakistan, classified chronotype by the

Morningness–Eveningness Questionnaire validated against forty-eight hours of core body-temperature monitoring, and randomised them to the same supervised aerobic programme at either chronotype-aligned or deliberately misaligned times of day.² Aligned training produced greater improvements in blood pressure, autonomic function, aerobic capacity, metabolic markers and sleep quality, and lowered systolic and diastolic pressure, fasting glucose and LDL more than mismatched timing.*when* — while noting the key weakness, that the paper is stronger on exercise timing than on circadian-phase measurement, since chronotype rests mainly on a questionnaire.²

THE CHATTER · WHAT COUNTS AS A MINUTE

The Hacker News thread on the 560-minute finding rejects it on time-budget grounds and does so bluntly — one comment reading, in full, that it is a joke, that nobody has time for that, and that it is more than a full day’s work — with commenters questioning whether anyone without a physically punishing job could reach the target.²

THE SCEPTIC · AND A CORRECTION TO THIS DESK’S OWN WEARABLE ITEM

Three limits on the lead. The cohort is ninety-six per cent white with a mean age of fifty-seven, so transportability is a live question.*trend* and treat any proprietary recovery score as a heuristic — with the useful observation, offered as commentary rather than research, that peer review lags hardware by two to four years, so the device on your finger is almost never the device that was validated.³

SOURCES 1 Dated honestly: the paper went online around mid-May 2026 and was re-covered in early August; no fitness study published in September 2026 could be verified to this page’s standard. Liang and colleagues, *British Journal of Sports Medicine*, DOI 10.1136/bjsports-2025-111351 — sample, design, thresholds, the twelve-per-cent attainment figure and the fitness-stratified dosing; the BMJ Group press release; news-medical and ScienceDaily for the two coverage waves, which date the paper to May with an August second wave. 2 Professor Aiden Doherty of the University of Oxford and the further expert reaction, quoted verbatim from the UK Science Media Centre; a parallel Spanish Science Media Centre panel. 3 The chronotype trial in *Open Heart*, 14 April 2026, PubMed 41980852 — design, sample, setting, findings and the authors’ stated limitations; Dr Jeffrey Kelu of King’s College London via the UK Science Media Centre; the BMJ Group release. The community read is the Hacker News thread, characterised in our own words with one comment quoted, and Steve Magness’s post of 11 December 2025, which concerns a different paper and is dated as such. The wearable validation: Dial and colleagues, *Physiological Reports* 2025 — thirteen participants, 536 nights, against a Polar H10 chest-strap reference; the peer-review-lag observation is commentary, not research. **General guidance, not medical advice.**

THE DIARY · THE DATED AGENDA

What's worth booking — sumo on sale tomorrow, a snow hall closing in twelve days, and a correction on BTS

The bookable calendar, Singapore and the region, each item hunted for its own cancellation before it was printed.

this story  

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

30
SEP

Snow City — final day, after twenty-six years

JURONG · THE "ONE LAST SNOWFALL" PACKAGE RUNS TO CLOSING: AN HOUR OF SNOW PLAY PLUS A BUMPER-CAR RIDE, S\$19 ADULT / S\$16 CHILD, FROM S\$27 / S\$23¹

9-11
OCT

★ F1 Singapore Grand Prix — the first Sprint weekend

MARINA BAY STREET CIRCUIT · RACE 8PM SUNDAY 11 OCT · SPRINT QUALIFYING FRIDAY, A STANDALONE 100KM SPRINT THEN GP QUALIFYING SATURDAY · ON SALE, SEVERAL OFFICIAL CATEGORIES SOLD OUT¹

10
OCT

The Killers — Padang Stage

AFTER SATURDAY QUALIFYING · INCLUDED WITH ANY RACE TICKET, BUT YOU MUST HOLD A SATURDAY TICKET¹

11
OCT

Lana Del Rey — Padang Stage

AFTER THE RACE · HER FIRST-EVER SINGAPORE CONCERT · SUNDAY TICKET REQUIRED¹

24
OCT

NCT 127 — 'Neo City: The Redline'

SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM, 7PM · SOLD OUT — RESALE ONLY¹

17-22
DEC

★ BTS — World Tour 'Arirang'

NATIONAL STADIUM, 7PM · FOUR NIGHTS: 17, 19, 20 AND 22 DEC — CORRECTING THIS DESK'S EARLIER LISTING · GENERAL SALE CLOSED 5 JUN, SO RESALE ONLY; ROUTE TICKETMASTER SG · THE LONGEST RUN IN ASIA OUTSIDE KOREA AND JAPAN²

21-24
JAN

ART SG 2027 — fifth edition

SANDS EXPO & CONVENTION CENTRE · PREVIEW AND VERNISSAGE 21 JAN, PUBLIC FAIR 22-24 · PART OF SINGAPORE ART WEEK²

JAPAN & THE REGION

PLAN THE FLIGHTS

8-22
NOV

★ Kyushu Basho — Grand Sumo

FUKUOKA KOKUSAI CENTER · GENERAL SALE TOMORROW, 19 SEP — THE OPENING TIME IS NOT PUBLISHED ANYWHERE, SO CHECK TICKET OOSUMO RATHER THAN TRUSTING A TIME · ENGLISH INTERFACE, OR A KONBINI TERMINAL IN JAPAN · WEEKENDS AND THE FINAL THREE DAYS GO WITHIN HOURS²

8
OCT

teamLab Borderless — 'Light Sculpture: Flow' closes

AZABUDAI HILLS, TOKYO · REOPENED 8 JUL WITH TWO NEW SERIES, INCLUDING ONE WHERE A SCULPTURE CASTS NO REFLECTION AND ANOTHER THAT EXISTS ONLY INSIDE THE MIRROR · 10AM-9PM, LAST ENTRY 8PM³

28
NOV

Niseko United — season opens

FOUR INTERCONNECTED RESORTS · NIGHT SKIING 12 DEC-22 MAR ACROSS ALL FOUR · ANNUPURI AND GRAND HIRAFU RUN TO 5 MAY³

PLANNING NOTES

Sumo is the clock this issue: the Kyushu Basho goes on general sale tomorrow, and the weekend days and final three bouts disappear within hours. At the Grand Prix, Friday is now worth more than it was, because Sprint Qualifying has moved there.²

And the family calculation. Snow City closes on the thirtieth, twelve days from now, after twenty-six years — the most time-critical line on the page for anyone with a child who has never been.¹

SOURCES Three Singapore dates were held rather than printed: a concert with conflicting October listings, an unconfirmed 2027 rugby date against a 2026 running of 31 January to 1 February, and a Christmas event whose window is single-sourced to a self-declared unofficial listing against the venue's own 2025 page. 1 Snow City's closing on 30 September after twenty-six years, the Science Centre Board decision and the farewell package and prices: Mothership; TTG Asia; Time Out Singapore and others — strongly multi-sourced, and a dedicated hunt for a reprieve found none. Grand Prix dates, the Sprint session order and the stage-access rules: formula1.com; Singapore GP's own account; Bandwagon Asia; KKday as the named authorised partner. A cancellation hunt returned only Bahrain and Saudi Arabia for 2026. 2 NCT 127, sold out: Ticketmaster Singapore's venue listing. BTS 'Arirang', four nights on 17, 19, 20 and 22 December, with general sale closed on 5 June: Live Nation Singapore as promoter; The Kallang as venue; the Singapore Tourism Board. A listings claim of an Indoor Stadium date in November is a conflation with another act and is not printed. ART SG 2027: ART SG's own site; Singapore Art Week. 3 Kyushu Basho and the Ticket Oosumo route: ozumo.jp's official schedule plus five further outlets corroborating the on-sale date; the opening time is not published in any reachable source and is not stated. teamLab: teamLab's official site; GO TOKYO. 4 Ski openings, labelled projected where the sources state they are not final: Japan Ski Experience; SkiJapan.com; OnTheSnow. Illuminations: GO TOKYO's winter guide; Japan Travel — switch-on dates are announced per venue and were unpublished at press time, so windows are given. The three held Singapore dates: conflicting listings for one, an unconfirmed 2027 edition against a 2026 running of 31 January to 1 February for another, and a self-declared unofficial listing against the venue's own 2025 page for the third.

THE TABLE · SINGAPORE'S NEWEST OPENINGS

A ninety-year eel house opens a second room, and a Tokyo hamburg counter where you order one thing

Four openings, reception researched rather than described. One is loved with a consistent caveat, one is loved and argued about on price, one is too new to have a body of opinion, and one is admired for its room rather than its plate — and this page says which is which.

Unagi Yondaime Kikukawa, Raffles City. The fresh peg here is a second outlet, not a debut: the Japanese house behind it has more than ninety years in sourcing and preparing eel and is run by its fourth-generation owner-chef, Kikukawa Yuhei, operating in Singapore in partnership with the Les Amis Group and Michelin-selected.¹ The craft is specific and worth knowing before you order: the house selects larger, thicker eels, and each is filleted and grilled to order over binchotan, which is what produces crisp skin against tender flesh rather than the uniform softness of a pre-grilled fillet.¹

The honest verdict: the brand is loved, this outlet is too new to call. The Shaw Centre original drew consistent, unhostile praise from local food media for freshness and charcoal work.¹

Hikiniku to Come, VivoCity. A Tokyo cult charcoal-grilled hamburg chain, for years one of the most queued-for names in that city, which opened here on 29 May. The format is the whole proposition: you order one thing.¹ This is the one that is genuinely loved. Time Out, SETHLUI, Eatbook and several local reviewers all landed positive, and the recurring verdict is that it is among the best Japanese hamburg available in Singapore.¹

Modu High, 96 Amoy Street. The elevated second act of Modu, Singapore's first premium samgyetang specialist, whose Mandarin Gallery original drew hour-long queues; it opened on 31 March.² Loved, with the pricing as the live argument. Eatbook, Time Out, HungryGoWhere and others covered it warmly on the strength of the broth and the room; the pointed dissent is best captured by the local reviewer

who filed it under the question of whether this is the Hermès of soup — which is precisely the premium-pricing scepticism worth putting to a reader who is about to book.²

Foura, at the IMBA Theatre, Gardens by the Bay. Opened 9 July in a four-thousand-square-foot glasshouse at the theatre entrance, cooking contemporary Asian and European food built on Blue Zones eating — the plant-forward, nutrient-dense patterns of unusually long-lived populations, here meaning grass-fed proteins, omega-rich seafood and high-polyphenol olive oil — with a weekly wellness programme of yoga, pilates, breathwork and a sound bath.² Here the reviews and the honest verdict diverge in an instructive way. The coverage is warm and consistent — and it is consistently about the glasshouse, the natural light, the garden views and the curated low-sensory music.²

THE BUZZ · WHERE THESE VERDICTS CAME FROM, AND WHERE THEY DID NOT

Every reception judgment on this page is synthesised from named Singapore food media — Eatbook, SETHLUI, HungryGoWhere, Time Out Singapore, The Peak, Tatler Asia, Her World, SG Food on Foot, middleclass.sg, littlebigreddot and The Ranting Panda — and characterised in this desk's own words.³

THE SCEPTIC · THREE OF THESE FOUR ARE NOT NEW

Hold this page to its own standard. The Table exists to tell a reader what has just opened, and on a strict reading only one of these four has a September peg: Kikukawa's Raffles City outlet. **Hikiniku to Come**, because it is the only one where the reviews, the format and the price all point the same way. Kikukawa is the one to watch and not yet the one to write about.

SOURCES 1 Unagi Yondaime Kikukawa: the house's ninety-plus years, the fourth-generation owner-chef, the Les Amis Group partnership and Michelin selection, the binchotan grilling, the whole-eel sets, address and booking route: Eatbook; HungryGoWhere; Great New Places; the restaurant's own channels. Reception on the Shaw Centre original from HungryGoWhere and The Ranting Panda; no substantive review of the Raffles City outlet exists and none is claimed. 2 Hikiniku to Come: the Tokyo parent, the May opening, the signature set and its contents, the seating and kiosk ordering and the walk-in digital queue: SETHLUI; Eatbook; Time Out Singapore; HungryGoWhere; the chain's own VivoCity page. Modu High: the March opening, the twelve flavours, the seat count, the Hanok-inspired fit-out and the opening hours: Eatbook; Time Out Singapore; HungryGoWhere; Little Day Out; the restaurant's own site, with the pricing critique from littlebigreddot. 3 Foura: the July opening, the glasshouse and its size, the Blue Zones concept, the wellness programme, the named dishes and price band, the seat counts and hours: HungryGoWhere; middleclass.sg; The Peak; Tatler Asia; Her World; Gardens by the Bay's official page. The absence of forum and social sentiment is stated as an absence; no Reddit or Burpple material is used or claimed.

THE UNDERCURRENT · SRI LANKA

The Battle for Solar Energy has a new front, and it runs through your fuse box

In 2016 Colombo launched a campaign with a war poster's name and persuaded tens of thousands of households to become electricity generators.

this story  

The programme was called සූර්ය බල සංග୍ରාමය — Soorya Bala Sangramaya, sun-power war, rendered in the government's own English as the Battle for Solar Energy.¹ It was launched in 2016 by the Ministry of Power and Renewable Energy with the Sustainable Energy Authority and the Ceylon Electricity Board, to put small solar plants on the roofs of houses, temples, hotels and factories.¹ As martial metaphors go it was unusually apt, because the state was raising an army: a civilian generating force, recruited house by house, financed household by household.

It won. In April 2021 there were 32,411 rooftop installations and 367 megawatts.¹ Today the figure is somewhere between roughly 1,200 and 1,700 megawatts — and that range, which we will come back to, is not sloppiness on this page but a genuine dispute in the sources.¹ Either way the thousand-megawatt target for 2025 was met or overshoot.

Nobody in Colombo said the other part out loud, which is that rooftop solar does not merely change where electrons come from. *isin* relation to the state.

A net-metered roof turns a customer into a creditor of a monopoly. Sri Lanka has discovered what an insolvent monopoly does when it cannot pay a creditor: it does not default in cash.

And an insolvent monopoly does not default in cash. First the asking: around five hundred commercial rooftop operators were curtailed and roughly a

hundred thousand other users were asked to switch their systems off across the April New Year holidays to hold the grid together — a figure reported by EconomyNext and the fact-checking site Climate Fact Checks, and one this desk dates to April 2025 with a caveat, because the year did not come through cleanly in the available reporting.² The control channel, at that stage, was a text message: owners were instructed to shut down on receipt of an SMS.²

Then the ordering. By early 2026 the Grid Connected Solar Power Association reported plants being told to shut not just at weekends but on two or three weekdays a week.² Between 10 and 20 April 2026 the Ceylon Electricity Board ordered every rooftop system above 300 kilowatts disconnected for ten days, citing collapsed holiday demand against high solar output.³ On 30 May 2026 power was cut to nearly a hundred areas to head off a blackout over the Vesak holiday.³

~100,000

HOUSEHOLDS ASKED TO SWITCH THEIR ROOFTOP SYSTEMS OFF OVER AN APRIL NEW YEAR HOLIDAY, ALONGSIDE SOME FIVE HUNDRED COMMERCIAL OPERATORS CURTAILED OUTRIGHT.

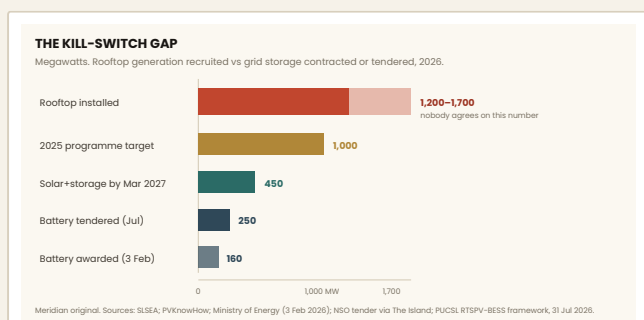
Then, in late June 2026, the thing this essay is about. Sri Lanka asked owners above 300 kilowatts to switch off at weekends and announced that it would *mandate modems* allowing the utility to disconnect them remotely, with installation hoped to be complete by December.³ Asked in Parliament by the opposition member Harsha de Silva whether the National System Operator actually has the legal power to do this, a deputy energy minister replied that the operator would act under the regulator's gazetted remit.³ On 27 August the operator asked again.⁴

SOURCES 1 The programme name, its 2016 launch, the agencies involved and the capacity targets: the Sri Lanka Sustainable Energy Authority; the UNESCAP Asia Pacific Energy Portal policy record. The 2030 figure appeared in one summary only. 2 The April 2021 baseline of installations and capacity: Sustainable Energy Authority figures carried in Asian Development Bank project material. The capacity range: PVKnowHow against reporting of approximately 1,700 megawatts facilitated by feed-in tariffs; a separate cumulative scheme figure carries no confirmed year. The conflict is unresolved and is treated as such throughout — see the sceptic on p23. 3 Scheme structures and the Net Plus tariff: the Public Utilities Commission of Sri Lanka; Sustainable Energy Authority scheme documentation — scheme-documented, not independently audited. The commercial curtailments, the hundred-thousand-household request and the text-message shutdown channel: EconomyNext; Climate Fact Checks. The year is dated with the caveat stated in the text. 4 Weekday curtailment in early 2026: the Grid Connected Solar Power Association via Climate Fact Checks. The ten-day shutdown of systems above 300 kilowatts: Colombo's *Daily FT* — not the London *Financial Times* — and *The Island*. The 30 May power cut: Newswire.lk. The modem mandate, the December target and the parliamentary exchange: EconomyNext; the deputy minister's full name could not be verified and is not printed. The renewed request of 27 August: Lanka Newspapers.

Set beside what the same state is simultaneously building, the modem looks less like engineering and more like arithmetic. On 3 February 2026 the Ministry of Energy approved the award of a tender for a 160-megawatt, 640-megawatt-hour standalone battery.¹ In July the National System Operator invited international bids for a 250-megawatt, 1,000-megawatt-hour battery, the largest the country has attempted, with proposals due on 14 August.¹ On 31 July the Public Utilities Commission published a framework requiring at least 450 megawatts of solar paired with storage by March 2027, setting a three-tier feed-in tariff, obliging distributors to assess and publish available network hosting capacity every month — and expressly reserving the licensee's and the operator's right to limit or curtail rooftop exports for system security.²

Add it up. Storage contracted or tendered across 2026: 410 megawatts, 1,640 megawatt-hours. Rooftop generation recruited: somewhere between 1,200 and 1,700 megawatts. The state enlisted three to four times more private generation than it has yet arranged steel to absorb, and the gap has to be closed by something. Batteries are the expensive way. A modem is the cheap way.

The batteries are the expensive answer to the surplus. The modem is the cheap one. Cheap answers are the ones that get built — and a switch, once wired in, is never unwired.



The state recruited three to four times more rooftop generation than it has contracted storage to absorb. The shaded band is the disagreement in the sources about how much rooftop solar Sri Lanka actually has.

Meanwhile the money keeps flowing the other way. In June 2026 the Asian Development Bank approved US\$57.4 million for a rooftop solar aggregation and virtual net-metering project supporting about 25 megawatt-peak — multilateral finance underwriting new rooftop solar while the grid operator switches the existing rooftop solar off.² The Ceylon Electricity Board has settled four billion rupees of arrears owed to rooftop customers, on a date this desk could not pin down and which changes the meaning considerably depending on which side of the curtailment it falls.³ The Solar Industries Association, which says it speaks for more than a thousand companies and some forty thousand workers, warns that the proposed tariff cut could collapse the lot; it is demanding compensation for curtailment, restoration of the Net Plus scheme, and — the telling demand — an independent audit of the utility's curtailment data.³

That last demand is the hinge of the whole story. The industry does not believe the utility's account of how often or why it is being switched off. And the utility cannot produce one, because most household systems are, in the sector's own word, invisible to the control room. Nobody knows how much energy has been curtailed. There is no credible figure, and this page will not invent one.

The discourse lives in the op-ed columns of *The Island* and Colombo's *Daily FT*, in installer and owner groups on Facebook where the shutdown texts circulate, and on r/srilanka. One *Island* op-ed is headlined, flatly, "Shutting roof top solar panels – a crime."⁴ An unusual feature of the affair is that a fact-checking outlet has become one of its principal chroniclers — which is what happens when the numbers themselves are contested.

SOURCES 1 The 160-megawatt, 640-megawatt-hour battery tender award of 3 February 2026: Sri Lanka's Ministry of Energy, primary source. The 250-megawatt, 1,000-megawatt-hour tender with bids due in August: *The Island*; Mercom India; Renewables Now. 2 The Public Utilities Commission's regulatory framework for rooftop solar with battery storage, dated 31 July 2026 — the three-tier feed-in tariff, the 450-megawatt target for March 2027, the monthly publication of network hosting capacity, and the expressly reserved right to curtail rooftop exports: the commission's own document, summarised in Colombo's *Daily FT*. 3 Asian Development Bank project 58280-001, approved in June 2026: the bank's own project record, primary source. The four-billion-rupee arrears settlement: the *Daily FT*; the date could not be established and is flagged as such. 4 Solar Industries Association claims and demands, including the call for an independent audit of curtailment data: *The Island*; Asian Mirror — membership and employment figures are self-reported by a trade association lobbying against a tariff cut, and are attributed rather than adopted. The op-ed headline: *The Island*. Community venues are named as reported, with no sentiment quoted verbatim.

This has been run before, on an island, in the richest country on earth. On 6 September 2013 roughly a third of Hawaiian Electric's residential circuits were already above a hundred per cent of daytime minimum load — the threshold past which the utility stopped waving interconnections through; the share later reached about half.¹ In October 2015 the Hawaii Public Utilities Commission closed net energy metering to all new applicants, abruptly, after some seventy thousand customers had joined.¹ The closure is credited with shrinking the local solar industry by around sixty per cent and costing some two thousand jobs — an industry-derived estimate, and labelled as one.¹ Hawaii's islanded, PV-saturated grid produced a duck curve so extreme that locals renamed it the Nessie curve, with non-solar demand going below zero on some days.² The eventual answer was storage: in July 2018 existing installations were opened to batteries.²

Hawaii is Sri Lanka's physics with none of Sri Lanka's politics. Same isolated grid, no interconnector, same saturation of daytime minimum load, same sequence — quiet interconnection freeze, then open curtailment, then abolition of the compensation scheme, then contraction, then batteries a decade late. *tariff*. A tariff reprices the future and leaves existing owners whole. Sri Lanka is reaching instead for the switch, which reaches backwards, into contracts already signed and property already owned. Hawaii solved its surplus by closing the door to new entrants.

Hawaii killed the tariff, which reprices the future. Sri Lanka is reaching for the switch, which reaches into the past — and into the property.

Hawaii also supplies the clock. It took roughly five years there to go from interconnection freeze to a storage-based answer.² That is a forecast, and this desk flags it as one. It is also, usefully, a test.

THE SCEPTIC · FOUR WAYS THIS ESSAY COULD BE WRONG

The engineering case is real. Sri Lanka's grid is islanded with no interconnector. Holiday demand collapses — April's New Year and May's Vesak are the recurring flashpoints — sunshine peaks, and the operator must de-load the hydro and thermal plants that supply not only electricity but rotating inertia, the thing that holds system frequency.³ A magazine that treats curtailment as pure villainy is wrong on the physics. **One expert says there is no crisis at all.** An energy expert told EconomyNext that the board's system control has been "amazing" at coping with rooftop solar it cannot even meter in real time — and if the operator is in fact managing, the modem is a convenience dressed as an emergency.³ **The headline number is a request, not a measurement.** The hundred thousand households were *asked*. No compliance rate was published, and because most domestic systems are invisible to the control room, nobody can say how much was curtailed. That is precisely why the industry is demanding an audit. **And the denominator is in dispute** — 1,200 against 1,700 megawatts, rooftop-only against all-solar — so every percentage claim anyone makes about this story, including the ones on the previous page, rests on a number two credible sources cannot agree on.³

So here is the falsification test, and it resolves inside a year. The thesis dies if the 160-megawatt battery energises, the 250-megawatt tender is awarded and built, the regulator's 450 megawatts of solar-plus-storage actually lands by March 2027, and April and May of 2027 pass without a shutdown order.

What generalises past Colombo is the sequencing. Distributed generation arrives years before distributed power, and in the gap between them a state under fiscal pressure writes itself a right of remote entry into a million rooftops. It does this for defensible engineering reasons, at a moment when nobody is watching, and it does it because the alternative costs money it does not have.⁴ It was the founding optimism of a whole era: that systems route around control. That is what makes this week's small, technical, unreported Sri Lankan procurement decision worth three pages.

SOURCES 1 Hawaiian Electric's residential circuits above daytime minimum load in September 2013: *Renewable Energy World*; the University of Hawaii Economic Research Organization. 2 The closure of net energy metering to new applicants in October 2015, after some seventy thousand customers had joined: *pv magazine*; *Utility Dive*. The subsequent industry contraction and job losses: *Honolulu Civil Beat* — an industry-derived estimate, labelled as one in the text. 3 The Nessie curve: the Institute for Energy Research; UHERO. Batteries opened to existing installations in July 2018: *pv magazine USA*. The National System Operator's forecast that forced shutdowns will end next year: the *Daily FT* — a forecast, flagged as one. 4 The cascading national failure attributed in part to the rooftop share: the Ceylon Electricity Board Engineers' Union via EconomyNext; its exact date could not be confirmed. The "amazing" system-control assessment: an energy expert, unnamed in the source, via EconomyNext. The audit demand: *The Island*; *Asian Mirror*. The Gilmore line: attributed to John Gilmore by Philip Elmer-DeWitt in *TIME*, 6 December 1993, and earlier by Howard Rheingold in September 1993; Gilmore has said publicly that he never found his own first use of it. See Quote Investigator.

MERIDIAN

THE LAST WORD

Who holds the off-switch

A good week for routing around things. Saudi crude stopped waiting for the Strait of Hormuz to reopen and started changing ships outside it, and the price fell for the first time since the shooting started.

And then the counter-examples, which are the ones worth keeping. A rooftop in Colombo cannot route around a modem: a state that spent a decade recruiting a hundred thousand households into generating its electricity is now fitting hardware so it can switch them off from the capital, because batteries cost money and a switch costs almost nothing.

Gilmore's line was true about a network of consenting peers. Information routes around control; barrels, roofs, motors and children do not, because they are physical and somebody owns the valve.

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A note on method. This edition was researched without the ability to open a single web page: the build environment's network policy blocked every publisher, journal and retailer domain, so all research ran through search. Prices, market levels and study details are therefore reported as surfaced rather than confirmed on the page, every figure this desk could not stand behind is either flagged in place or absent, and each desk carries its own numbered sources. Nothing here was invented to fill a gap. Full source lists appear on the desk pages.